

THE LOST WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS.

One of the Strange Stories of Santa Barbara, California.

Seventy miles from the shore is San Nicolas Island, the sixth of the group that cluster around the Bay of Santa Barbara. It is celebrated for having been the residence for nineteen years of "The Lost Woman of San Nicolas." As her name is famous and her story has been told in romance I will give the bare facts about her as I found them to be, without any added ornament, and leave the fiction to the pen of the novelist.

The Island of San Nicolas was once densely populated. This is attested by the skulls and bones and other evidences of human abode that are found there. The Alaska Indians frequently visited the island to hunt for the furs of the sea otter. They took their women with them on these hunts, and on returning after the hunt was over they left them on the island to their fate. By order of the Government in 1855 the Indians were removed from the island. Just before they were to embark and carry away every human inhabitant, as it was supposed, a white Indian woman begged for the privilege of going ashore for her child, which was acci-

Indian woman began to beg for the privilege of going ashore for her child, which was accidentally left. She was gone a long time in a fruitless search for her offspring. The wind blew a gale, the water was shallow, there was one who was seeking the lost one. They set sail, intending to return for the lost woman of San Nicolas, but the boat, becoming unseaworthy, she was left to her fate. It was generally known that there was a woman abandoned on the island, but no attempt was made for her deliverance. As the world soon forgets, so the woman of San Nicolas was forgotten and the year passed away. After a lapse of sixteen years a man who landed on the island found that it was inhabited by some one. The foot-prints of a human being sunk deep in the ground was seen. The hardness of the ground was an indication that they had been made a long time. From their size they evidently belonged to a woman. Circular inclosures made of brush, six or seven feet through, were seen, where some one had lived. Near the huts were sticks driven in the ground and dried blubber hanging on them, thus prepared for food.

In 1852 San Nicolas was visited again, and another hunt was made for the long-lost woman. The huts were seen that had been seen before, but the old blubber had been taken away and new food of the kind hung in its place. Wild dogs were found which ran away at the approach of civilized man. In a basket covered with seal-skins

which ran away at the approach of civilized man. In a basket covered with seal-skins that they found in a bush heap was a dress made of shag-skins, cut in square pieces, a rope made of sinew, and several smaller articles, such as fish hooks and bone needles. The discoverers of these proofs that there lived on that island a human being scattered them on the ground, and on their return they found them gathered together and placed in the basket again.

The Catholic Fathers of the "Old Mission," the foremost in every good word and work, offered a reward to any one who would find the lost woman, and a third effort was made in 1853 to discover the prodigal about whom there was such a mystery, and in whom the world of this coast was beginning to take an interest. Fresh tracks of the woman were found. They belonged to very small feet, and were like those that were seen in the first attempt to find the woman. Huts made of whale ribs and covered with brush were discovered. At length an object was seen in the distance that appeared to be moving. Going toward it they saw the woman that for sixteen years had reigned Queen of San Nicholas, her subjects being the wild animals, her robe a dress of bird skins she had made, and her throne the hut she had built. She was seated in an inclosure, so that only her head and shoulders could be seen. Two or three dogs were about her that disappeared at the command of their sovereign. She was seated on some grass that covered the ground and served her as a bed. Her dress was neatly made of

grass that covered the ground and served her as a bed. Her dress was neatly made of bird skins, extending to her ankles, the feathers of which pointed downward. Her head was covered with a thick mat of yellowish brown hair, and her shoulders were bare. She was occupied in stripping blubber from a piece of sealskin which she held across her knee, and using for that purpose a knife made of an iron hoop. In her hut was a fire, beside which she sat talking to herself and, occasionally shading her eyes with her hand, looked at the men that were in search of her. She received them with much courtesy, bowing and smiling and showing that this lost child of nature had much of the politeness of a true woman. She took some roots in the bag, roasted them in the fire, and gave them to the men to eat. She gathered up all her food, which was her chief concern, owing to the famines she had experienced, washed herself at the spring, and followed the men cheerfully to the boat. On being taken to Santa Barbara she manifested great delight on seeing the sights of civilization. She became a universal favorite and was presented with many gifts. Passengers on the Panama steamer that landed there all wanted to see the lost woman of San Nicolas. She related by signs her experience on the island, as she spoke a language that none of the Indians knew and none of the Spanish Fathers, versed in Indian dialects, could understand. Civilization, which prolongs the life of some, shortened that of the woman of San Nicolas. An excessive love of fruit led to her death.

An excessive love of fruit led to her death in Santa Barbara at the age of fifty. She was buried with the honors of the Catholic Church by the Franciscan Fathers, and her dress and trinkets were sent to Rome and placed in that receptacle of the world's curiosities.

The story of the lost woman of San Nicolas will always remain a wonderment. Her ingenuity is seen in the pails she made of grass, made to hold water by smearing them with melted asphaltum, and in her bird skin dresses, her bone needles, her knife of iron hoop, and the language she invented and spoke. It is inexplicable to all who have learned her story how a woman could live eighteen years on an island around which the waves were beating a requiem to hope, getting her food and cooking it without even those facilities which are common to the savage, and making her dresses neatly without the aid of needles except what she carved out of bone. She laid aside one dress for eighteen years, to be worn when the white men should come, of which she had a presentiment. She built her own house, protected herself from the cold, gained supreme control over the wild beasts about her and preserved her love for men and women for well nigh two decades of human life alone in the wild. With no previous knowledge of civilization, solitude appeared to have educated her for it. An ordinary woman would have perished with despondency in such a desolate, hungry, naked, shelterless outlook.
